

Artisans in the Bearing Manufacturing Business

Words by: Executives Team

Working with National Engineering Industries Ltd for 25+ years makes him a well-respected bearings maestro.

Mr. Rohit Saboo's journey within the company starts with him as the Executive Assistant to the former Chairman and renowned industrialist Mr Chandra Kant Birla, to becoming the Head of R&D and Manufacturing and finally taking over the reins as President and CEO at NEI.

National Engineering Industries

National Engineering Industries (NEI) was established in 1946. Bearings are machine components used for reducing friction for smooth rotation and are commonly used in the automotive, railway and industrial sectors. NEI has been a leading manufacturer and exporter in the industry for over six decades. The company exports to 21 countries spreading across five continents including the US, Japan, Australia, Germany and Brazil.

"It was the best learning experience for me."

Rohit graduated from Birla Institute of Technology in Ranchi and did his MBA in Rochester Institute of Technology, NY. After completing his Senior Executive Program from Columbia, he started working as Executive Assistant

to the prestigious Mr. C K Birla. When asked about it, he says

"I worked with him for 4 and a half years and let's just say that it was the best learning opportunity for me. The kind of experience I have gotten while working with him, the kind of person he is - he would explain everything to me such as explaining why things happen and he kept me involved in all the company's ventures. We had hired a few growth consultants back then for a few projects and I was involved in everything. I would say that this was a wonderful learning experience for me and I think that this was when I had matured in terms of my thinking wherein I was faster than other people at my age."

At the Helm

Rohit was instated as the Head of R&D and Manufacturing back in 2000, but it wasn't an easy progression, he admits. He sensed a need to change the long-established ways of the company.

"There were a lot of people and inessential practices and I wanted to improve the quality of our products," he says.

He knew he wanted to change the

structure of the organization to make it work towards the future without focusing on past laurels. His main focus was to ensure that the quality of their products could match the standards of any product in the world and that the company's productivity was fully utilized. And he did ensure that these were done, regarding it as a valuable experience. They focused on spending money into research into what products and where they would be useful in the industry and the area of expertise of the people required in this process.

"We also focused on continuous quality improvement of our products by delving into established techniques such as ppam** wherein the first step taken was to improve the machinery conditions to improve the optimum level & TQM concentration levels which are done to bring our process under control for the best quality of our products in the world."

"We are comparable to anyone in the world as far as quality is concerned" he confidently says. "We are also recognized as a Total Quality Management (TQM) company and

Mr. Rohit Saboo
(President - CEO)

National Engineering Industries Ltd

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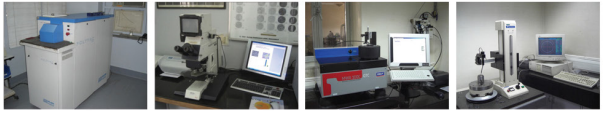
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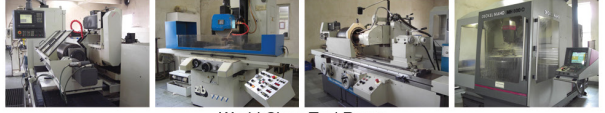
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we are the only company in the world to have received the Demi Grand Prize from the Japanese Union of Scientists and Engineers.”

NEI is the first bearings manufacturing industry in the world to have received this accreditation. Putting aside all their business excellence, Rohit had bigger plans back then. Besides collaborating with ntn** and Branco** they were keen on growing much bigger on their own.

Getting the team together:

“We invested money to increase our R&D capacity and got a lot of people on board. At Least 20-30% of our team members have PhDs and masters in the research field.” Due to Rohit’s vision, they were able to expand on their credibility.

“We did a lot of training in research with these folks and that’s why we’ve been able to expand our product portfolio. In retrospect, these were the key things I concentrated on since 2008.”

Growth plans amidst COVID-19

NEI is generally considered as one of

the fastest-growing companies in the nation. With corona virus being the new normal in our world, most businesses have slowed down. According to Rohit, things have slowed down temporarily. He says that they plan on doubling their turnover by the end of 2025.

“We have aggressive growth plans, both organic and inorganic. Organically speaking, we will keep evolving our portfolio based on each landscape and particular requirements.” The company plans on launching an entirely new product range of medium roller bearings in the next few months.

“We are already investing almost 100+ crores in that. In the coming period, a lot of our R&D projects will be completed such as bearings for electric vehicles, smart bearings, high-speed bearings, 40 electric vehicle motors and other applications. And also some bearings for industrial applications.”

Fact: National Engineering Industries has been partnering with Indian railways for several decades now.

“Nowadays, the Indian railway’s

bearing requirement has also been changing so we are adapting ourselves simultaneously. You know the vision of Make in India and Atma nirbhar right? Everybody is starting to import and we have already started supplying to Indian railways.” He concludes his statement by saying that this remains the agenda for the 2-3 years. Here’s what he had to say about their next course of action.

“In the next term, we will explore aerospace and the defense segment. We feel that we can contribute to the Indian defense, aerospace and space exploration departments. Most of the bearings which are used, at least in aerospace and space exploration are imported so we want to change that as well as part of the atma nirbhar or ‘self-sufficient India’ vision.

Treading international waters

Considering the international market, 20% of their turnover comes from exports and Rohit says that their mission is to increase it to 30%.

“We have recently acquired a European bearing company called Kinex in Slovakia intending to boost



we provide
high precision steel balls

we surround
you
silently







our presence in
automobile industry



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our presence in Europe and we will use their footprint to grow both companies. We also continue to look for other opportunities to fuel our growth. I think doubling our turnover by 2025 is a good target for us.”

Expansion plans and key areas of focus

“We are a company where continuous improvement is in our bloodstream, you can say. We continue to strive through and do better from what we have done previously. For example, reduce our tolerances and improve our products, we continue to respond to customers much faster than before, we continue to improve the time and efficiency of producing a bearing and we’ll improve our research ability in finding new materials, heating techniques and anything related to our industry.”

“Our goal is to provide a really good product no matter how stringent the requirements are.”

Leaner, smart and completely digitized
Being the President and CEO of a leading bearing manufacturing industry surely keeps Rohit up to date with the technology industry.

“We have embarked on our journey towards Industry 4.0 and we hope to be completely digitalized within the next three years, meaning every automation process that we do, we’ll take all our data and even digitize products such as smart bearings. These are the key areas which we are moving ahead with which will eventually make us leaner, smarter and an organization that creates value for our customers.”

It is also very apparent, not once, but several times throughout the conversation that Rohit is a proud supporter of the country.

“We take immense pride in our Make in India credential. We were the first bearing manufacturing company in India established in 1946 and we’ve grown substantially in the last 75 years since then. We have collaborated with the best to deliver the best quality products providing immense value to our customers. What differentiates us is our focus and our commitment towards our R&D,” he says.

He further explains that they have the largest R&D setup in the country with a testing and validation facility of the

best standards.

“All our customers whether Indian or international rely on us to test their products for them. This helps us mutually in the sense that we ensure our service is faster and the customer gets value-added services.”

The largest portfolio of products in the country

With more than 2800 employees and present in 30+ countries, the company has 200 million bearings and 1450 sizes in their product catalogue.

“We always keep evolving based on the needs of our customers. It’s not that we design a product and then simply produce it, instead, we tweak the product to ensure it gives the best performance according to a customer’s requirement. As we keep adding more products, I would say that we have a much faster response time when it comes to our competitors and we hope to continue to improve our response time with customers. Another differentiator is that whatever we invest in, we always ensure that we get the best machinery and facilities in

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A KEY MESSAGE TO ALL

the world and our production plants and staff are the best in class around the world.”
“Our people are our biggest differentiator.”

Maintaining a strong synergy with their suppliers

The company’s first vendor base was established long ago in Jaipur where they now have a strong system-oriented structure. The vendor base is so well developed that even contemporaries use it for their products, claims Rohit.

“We have always maintained a long term relationship with whoever we work with. We had a lot of time and enough money to bring our vendor base to a world-class level. Because when we first started, most of our vendors were pretty small and some of them still are. So we invested in helping them to develop further by encouraging them to grow by giving them more business opportunities. We always support vendors with the right attitude and have even provided financial support when necessary.”

He further mentions that an efficient supply chain can help you with everything in business starting from a quick supply to turnover time.

“All the suppliers we have worked with for a long time. We were always very close with our suppliers and the first attribute we look at is the quality and attitude of the supplier we deal with. We do not compromise on our supplier base at any cost.”

To encourage excellence in the suppliers’ standards, the NEI Rewards and Recognition Program encourages all suppliers to meet expectations for every opportunity.

“As I had mentioned earlier that we support our suppliers, similarly our suppliers have supported us during difficult times such as during recession earlier in 2008. They had supported us. Even during this COVID

time, they have supported us through April and May and in turn we supported them but this creates a great synergy between us. Because we invest a lot of our energy to teach them productivity and quality improvements, TQM, etc. Whatever we have learned we try and pass it on to our vendors. So they appreciate that.”

“I have the confidence that our suppliers would choose us over our competitors.”

Insight into their critical supplier strategy

“All of our suppliers, whether small or big, whatever they supply would eventually be for our customers, but of course, there are some suppliers who just because of their sheer size we may be more dependent on them. I would say that there are around 15 suppliers who we are quite dependent on in terms of critical suppliers,” he notes.

A key message to all

It is quite evident that Rohit’s driving vision has ushered the company to the position it is at right now. Before signing off, he emphasized on the importance of taking this time to analyze and adopt to the current environment.

“Since everyone is currently in survival mode due to the pandemic, I would say that this is the time to press the restart button, in the sense, analyze the entire supply chain, remove the waste and become more lean and efficient so that whenever the situation becomes normal, you’ll be in a position of a much stronger company and you’ll revive much faster than those who have a higher base or cost structure. This is the time of thinking and innovation and also executing things. We may have to make difficult decisions or do something slightly out of the ordinary, but I think the world as we know it has changed and we have to be very well prepared for it.” he explains, speaking like a true industrialist.